



Red Desert Il deserto rosso

Director: Michelangelo Antonioni

Production Companies: Film Duemila, Francoriz

Presented by: Angelo Rizzoli

Producer: Antonio Cervi

Production Manager: Ugo Tucci

Unit Production Managers: Rodolfo Martello,

Dino Di Salvo

Assistant Directors: Gianni Arduini, Flavio Nicolini

Script Supervisor: Serena Canevari

Story and Screenplay: Michelangelo Antonioni,

Tonino Guerra

Director of Photography: Carlo Di Palma

Camera Operator: Dario Di Palma

Assistant Cameramen: Alberto Spagnoli,

Giovanni Antinori

Editor: Eraldo Da Roma

Art Director: Piero Poletto

Set Decorator: Sergio Donà

Costumes: Gitt Magrini

Make-up: Franco Freda

Hairstylist: Giancarlo De Leonardis

Music: Giovanni Fusco

Electronic Music from Compositions by:

Vittorio Gelmetti

Singer: Cecilia Fusco

Music Director: Carlo Savina

Sound Recordist: Claudio Maielli

Sound Mixer: Renato Cadueri

Cast:

Monica Vitti (*Giuliana*)

Richard Harris (*Corrado Zeller*)

Carlo Chionetti (*Ugo*)

Xenia Valderi (*Linda*)

Rita Renoir (*Emilia*)

Lili Rheims (*worker's wife*)

Aldo Grotti (*Max*)

Valerio Bartoleschi (*Valerio, Giuliana's son*)

Emanuela Pala Carboni (*girl in the fable*)

Italy-France 1964

117 mins

Digital 4K (restoration)

4K Restoration by Cinecittà and

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Monica Vitti: Creative Force

Red Desert

Against the backdrop of a bleak industrial landscape, a traumatised woman embarks on an affair. Antonioni's first colour film critiques industrialisation and reflects on fragmented human connection in a rapidly changing society. Vitti, starring alongside Richard Harris, gives a devastating performance as the fragile Giuliana, who is searching for something she cannot name. The film won the Golden Lion at the 1965 Venice Film Festival.

Antonioni on 'Red Desert'

In *Red Desert* I used colour for the first time. I don't think that's particularly significant since colour is such a part of modern society. Many colour films I have seen have fascinated me and at the same time left me unsatisfied. Because while, on the one hand, they gave me a more realistic picture of the external reality of people and things, on the other hand, the colours were never the right ones to fully capture the feelings generated by the relationships between people and things. I have, therefore, tried to exploit each and every narrative resource of colour in such a way that it contributed to the mood of each sequence.

The similarities in certain new ways of utilising colour in modern cinema – I'm thinking for example of Resnais and Bergman – is not a coincidence. It's a need that we directors have all felt at the same time, because it's connected to expressing the reality of our times, which in my opinion is something that cannot ignore colour. In *Red Desert*, we are in an industrial world which every day produces millions of objects of all types, all in colour. Just one of these objects is sufficient – and who can do without them? – to introduce into the house an echo of industrial living. Thus, our houses are full of colour, and our streets and public places are full of colourful posters. With the invasion of colours we have become addicted to them.

I always thought of *Red Desert* in colour. The idea for it came to me as I was going through the countryside around Ravenna. I was born in Ferrara, which is about 70 kilometres from Ravenna, and for a long time I went there many times a year for different reasons. The violent transformation of the countryside around the city has had a strong effect on me. Before, there were immense groves of pine trees, very beautiful, which today are completely dead. Soon even the few that have survived will die and give way to factories, artificial waterways, and docks. This is a reflection of what is happening in the rest of the world. It seemed to be the ideal background for the story I had in mind – naturally, a story in colour.

The world that the characters in the film come into conflict with isn't the world of factories. Behind the industrial transformation lies another one – a transformation of the spirit, of human psychology. This new way of life conditions the behaviour of both those who work in the factories and of those who, outside of it, suffer its effects. The characters in *Red Desert* are in close contact with the industrial world. Giuliana, the protagonist, is a neurotic. She cannot adapt to the new 'way' of life and she goes through a crisis, while her husband, on the other hand, is content with his lot in life. And then there is Corrado. He has almost got to the point of neurosis and thinks he can cure himself by going to Patagonia.

I'm not against progress. But there are people who, by their nature, by their moral makeup, have to wrestle with the modern world and can't manage to adapt to it. And thus we witness a sort of process of natural selection: the ones

Monica Vitti: Creative Force

Clever Girls Le dritte

Sat 1 Aug 14:50; Mon 10 Aug 20:40 (+ intro by writer Richard Dyer)

Red Desert Il deserto rosso

Sun 2 Aug 12:10; Sat 8 Aug 14:30;
Sun 16 Aug 15:00; Mon 24 Aug 20:40

L'eclisse The Eclipse

Sun 2 Aug 18:10; Sun 9 Aug 15:00 (+ intro by season curator Catherine O'Rawe);
Thu 13 Aug 20:30

Modesty Blaise

Mon 3 Aug 18:00; Sat 22 Aug 14:50

Monica Vitti Season Introduction

Thu 6 Aug 18:10

L'avventura The Adventure

Thu 6 Aug 20:20; Thu 20 Aug 18:00

I Married You for Fun Ti ho sposato per allegria

Sat 8 Aug 12:00; Wed 12 Aug 20:30 (+ intro by writer and researcher Olga Campofreda)

Teresa the Thief Teresa la ladra

Sat 8 Aug 18:00; Tue 18 Aug 20:35

La notte The Night

Sat 8 Aug 20:30; Wed 26 Aug 18:10
(+ pre-recorded intro by Joanna Biggs)

Stardust Polvere di stelle

Sun 9 Aug 17:50 (+ intro by season curator Catherine O'Rawe); Tue 18 Aug 18:00

Tosca La Tosca

Tue 11 Aug 18:10; Sat 29 Aug 12:20

The Oberwald Mystery Il mistero di Oberwald

Fri 14 Aug 18:10; Sat 29 Aug 18:00

The Girl with a Pistol La ragazza con la pistola

Wed 19 Aug 18:10; Sat 29 Aug 20:55

I Know That You Know That I Know

Io so che tu sai che io so

Thu 20 Aug 20:45; Mon 31 Aug 12:00

Secret Scandal Scandalo segreto

Mon 24 Aug 18:30; Thu 27 Aug 20:45

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who survive are those who manage to keep up with progress, while the others disappear, swallowed up by their crises. Because progress is inexorable, like revolutions. In the same way that some people suffer during a revolution, there is also a malaise connected to progress. It's life itself and there is nothing extraordinary about that.

I tried to show characters who cannot adapt, because it is in them that this situation becomes a drama. Giuliana lives through a profound crisis because of her inability to adapt to the modern world. And it is not by chance that there was only one scene in which I used colour 'normally' – that is, leaving colours their natural hues. It is the scene in which Giuliana, having run out of stories to tell her sick son, makes one up with great simplicity and purity of heart. In that sequence, the plot is suspended, as if the eye and the conscience of the narrator had been distracted elsewhere. In fact, that sequence, in which each element – and first of all, colour – tells a fragment of human experience, shows reality as Giuliana wishes it were – that is, different from the world that appears to her as transformed, alienated, obsessive to the point of being monstrously deformed.

The electronic music, a sort of transfiguration of real noises – especially in the first part of the film, the part about the factories – finds a counterpoint in the sounds that Giuliana hears. It was the only musical score that seemed suited to those images. But, how to explain the unfocused areas that highlight certain other parts of the frames? The truth is that it's only while you shoot that you find the right technique for telling a story. While I was working on my first film, I felt the need to shoot some very long takes. Only afterward did I understand why. For *Red Desert*, on the other hand, I chose very short takes. Perhaps it was the fact that I was using colour that suggested this technique to me, this deep-seated need to deal with it in large blotches, as if they were pulsations that penetrate chaotically inside the characters.

I think the background that you see as the title credits roll is very beautiful. The colours are superb. In the countryside around Ravenna, the horizon is dominated by factories, smokestacks and refineries. The beauty of that view is much more striking than the anonymous mass of pine trees which you see from afar, all lined up in a row, the same colour. The factory is a more varied element, more lively, because behind it one can detect the presence of man and human life, his dramas and hopes. I am in favour of progress, and yet I realise that because of the disruption it brings, it also causes trouble. But that is modern life, and the future is already knocking on our door.

Red Desert isn't really a continuation of my previous work. Before, the environment in which my characters lived was described indirectly through their own positions, their psychology and feelings and backgrounds. What those films were most about was the personal relationships of the characters. In *Red Desert*, I wanted to highlight more the relationship between the characters and the world around them. I tried, therefore, to rediscover the traces of ancient human feelings which are buried nowadays under a welter of conventions, gestures, and rhythms that amount to substitutes; and under a conciliatory 'public-relations' jargon that hides our true feelings. It's almost like being an archaeologist, digging through dry and arid material of the modern age. If this kind of 'digging' shows through more clearly in *Red Desert*, it is also because our world is slowly becoming easier to study.

Interview by François Maurin. Originally published in *Humanité dimanche*, 23 September 1964.

Translated by Andrew Taylor for publication in *The Architecture of Vision* (Marsilio, 1996)